



Filed After the Fact

Reversal Rationales in Committee Minutes and the Incidents They No Longer Cite

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Introduction

Assessment committees across the University have returned finals to in-person invigilation, each citing academic-integrity risk. Reversals are well documented. But a decision's recorded reason is written at the point of resolution, not the point of concern. Does the justification that survives into the minute still name what prompted the item?

What we set out to test

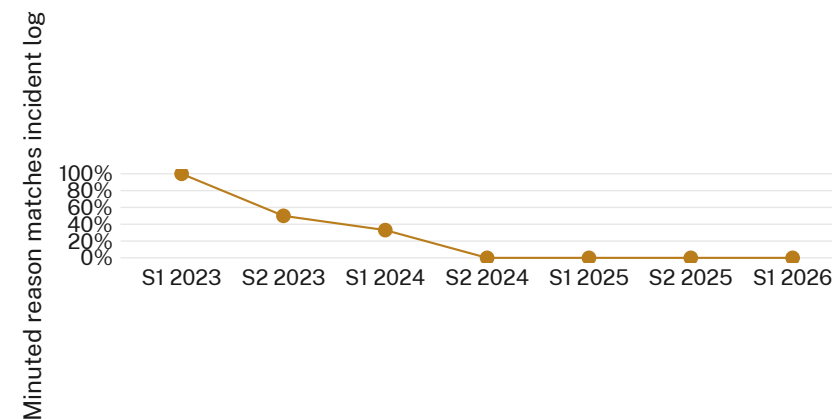
- Whether a reversal's minuted reason cites the incident live on the integrity log when the item was first tabled.
- How the reason-to-incident match changes with time-to-resolution.
- What chairs recall as the reason, against what their minutes record.

Materials & methods

- 24 reversal decisions · 7 teaching periods · minutes cross-read against the dated integrity log · three coders, blind to period.
- 19 semi-structured chair interviews, conducted before coders released the matched log extracts.
- Coding frame pre-registered; no category added post hoc; inter-coder agreement $\kappa = 0.81$.

What we found

Median time from first tabling to resolution was 7.5 months. Reason-to-incident match falls across the period; chairs interviewed named the incident correctly more often than their own minutes recorded it.



Share of reversals citing the incident live at tabling (n = 24). None minuted after S2 2024 cites its originating incident.

Interpretation

The minute preserves not the reason but the reason available when it was written. An item tabled against one incident resolves months later against whichever concern is current. Chairs remember the first; the institution reviews against the second.

Next: a paired re-read at the next review, testing whether the substitution recurs.

Further reading

1. Cohen, M. D., March, J. G. & Olsen, J. P. (1972). A Garbage Can Model of Organizational Choice. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 17(1), 1–25. doi:10.2307/2392088
 2. Staw, B. M. (1976). Knee-deep in the Big Muddy: A Study of Escalating Commitment to a Chosen Course of Action. *Organizational Behavior and Human Performance*, 16(1), 27–44. doi:10.1016/0030-5073(76)90005-2
 3. Feldman, M. S. (2000). Organizational Routines as a Source of Continuous Change. *Organization Science*, 11(6), 611–629. doi:10.1287/orsc.11.6.611.12529
 4. de Holan, P. M. & Phillips, N. (2004). Organizational Forgetting as Strategy. *Strategic Organization*, 2(4), 423–433. doi:10.1177/1476127004047620
 5. Bilen, E. & Matros, A. (2021). Online Cheating Amid COVID-19. *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*, 182, 196–211. doi:10.1016/j.jebo.2020.12.004
- De-identified records; School of Emergent Priorities seed grant.

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“Every reversal was justified. Rarely by the thing that started it.”

Of 24 reversals returned to in-person invigilation, none minuted after S2 2024 cites the incident that was live when the item was tabled.